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Alan Raph

Alan Raph was born in New York City on July 3, 1933. He came from a musical family and has fashioned a successful career as a trombonist and low brass player. Alan has played for most of the major names in the classical and jazz world, including Eugene Ormandy, Villa Lobos, Quincy Jones and Gerry Mulligan. He earned a "Most Valuable Player" award from the National Association of Recording Arts & Sciences and currently sustains a multifaceted career as a performer, composer and educator.

Alan was interviewed in Danbury, Connecticut on November 20, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Danbury, Connecticut. I'm pleased to have Alan Raph with me today. I'm wondering, what do you put on your income tax form as your occupation?

AR: Musician.

MR: That covers a lot of things for you, doesn't it?

AR: Yeah. I put musician, slash — well for my wife and I — musician, music teacher, but it goes both ways.

MR: What does your daughter think? You have a ten year old?

AR: I have a ten year old, yes.

MR: Does she have a sense of what you do?

AR: Sort of. She has a sense of what I do now which is somewhat different than what I did let's say twenty years ago, because I had a long life before she came along. And I have two kids that are actually older than me at this point you know. I have a 43-year-old and I have a 36-year-old, a couple of grandkids in California.

MR: Wow. So you have kind of a whole second career.

AR: Yeah. Second family, second life. What does she think? She knows of course that I'm a musician, she knows that I conduct the Danbury Brass Band because she's been to many concerts, she knows that I teach around here, I teach right now at the moment at the Emmanuel Lutheran School, I do a couple of hours a week there teaching general music, which I asked for rather than trombone or instruments or that. And she knows that I sit with her every morning for an hour and she practices piano, which we did this morning included. She has been playing for five years and she's got a remarkably good ear and a good musical sense and she has her struggles are more with reading notes. That is where we kind of have to pound things into her. But she's getting there.

MR: Yeah. Does she like to improvise a little bit?

AR: Very little. She's not sure what it is. But just recently — she is singing in a choir on Sundays. And they're going to give a concert. And the choir director brought out a particular piece of music that has a flute solo at the beginning and he said well if anybody plays flute or recorder or tin whistle or anything, audition for it and we'll have you play the solo. So she asked me to borrow a flute, which I did from one of the guys in the Brass Band, and she practiced it, and she'd been playing for a week and a half and she played the solo and the guy said okay. So she came home, she said, "I got the gig."

MR: All right. She's getting the terms down.

AR: She's getting the terms down. She's got a good sense of humor. And her mother of course is a musician. My wife is a string player. So between strings and brass, of course naturally she's going to gravitate toward the woodwinds. For new expenses.

MR: Sure. So you have to pay somebody else to give the lessons?

AR: Right. Exactly.

MR: Well you're a trombone player.

AR: A trombone player primarily. Bass trombone specifically, although I play related instruments, tenor and baritone horn and tuba. I've done a lot of work on the other instruments too. But basically I guess my reputation is bass trombone. I've been doing that for some years.

MR: And you grew up in New York City?

AR: I grew up in Brooklyn.

MR: A musical family?

AR: A musical family. My father was a musician. He ended up — well he ended up out of work — but in his heyday he conducted the "Stop the Music" television show and he conducted "Name that Tune," the original shows back in the '50s. And he played, in his day, when he was in his 20s he played trombone with Dixieland groups, including Phil Napoleon and some of those in New York City. So when it came time for me to take music, I took piano at age eight, and when I went into high school at age fourteen I went to Brooklyn Tech of all places, and in order to avoid the lunchroom lines which were enormous, I went down to the basement. There was a sign you could take music lessons and I ended up signing up for the trombone. So I started trombone in high school. And went to New York University, took music education, which in those days I felt, or we all felt, you know, those interested in my career were thinking that this would be a good thing to fall back on in case things didn't work out musically.

MR: This was the late —

AR: Mid-50s actually, yeah. Well I went to NYU from '51 to '55. And things did work out so I managed to do fairly decently professionally. Ten years later, in '65, I decided to go

back for a master's so I went to Teacher's College, Columbia, and I got a master's in Music Education.

MR: Were your parents supportive of you going into music?

AR: It was almost a gimme. It was just something to do. My father was in music, my mother didn't much, she liked music and all, it was just the way to go. I took piano and when I was taking piano lessons at age eight, nine and ten I had visions of being a concert pianist. Music has always been kind of the goal. And my father did impress one thing on me which was really good and that is to do it all. To do as many different kinds of music as I could. So I made that a campaign. When I played trombone, and my first jobs on trombone I was lucky, I got a Broadway show almost right off the bat when I was twenty years old. After that I started paying dues. Because when the show closed I had nothing and I went out with Sammy Kaye on the road, I played with American Opera Society in New York City, I played a lot of subbing at the Radio City Music Hall, and doing shows and doing this kind of thing, plus playing the symphony against the popular or dance music end of it, kind of pointed me in the direction of being able to at least make contacts in the various fields of music. So on my dossier I write charter member of the American Symphony Orchestra with Leopold Stokowski, and at the same time I was a charter member of Gerry Mulligan's concert jazz band. And in those days, while it wasn't — it was rare, it wasn't not heard of — but it was fairly rare to do both ends of the spectrum. I got a lot of raised eyebrows from various people along the way, until I finally realized that when I'm talking with jazz people I don't talk classical, and when I'm talking with symphony people I don't mention that I just did Birdland the night before.

MR: They don't feel that it's really appropriate to be doing that?

AR: At that time it was — what would I say — I won't say threatening, that's not a good word because I was too young in the stage of my career to be threatening to anybody. But when you're talking, you know, back stage with a group of classical musicians, symphony musicians, the talk is about the symphony world and about the connections and the contractors and the opportunities and all of that. And then to pull in, well I played Birdland last night or I've been doing this, that and the other, it's almost like stopping the conversation. Well okay, that's nice, and what were we talking about now, you know.

MR: Why would you do that I guess. Is it harder to rise in the ranks of the classical world or in the jazz world?

AR: The first thing I noticed, I did the classical world first. I was doing shows and I was doing symphony orchestras, I played with the Symphony of the Air and various, like I said, the American Opera Society and various groups before I really got into the commercial end of it, which came about through my having a spare weekend and I went out with Larry Elgart and did a few, about a half year with him. And it segued into Gerry Mulligan with

the concert jazz band. I found on the way up that jazz musicians had ears. They could hear way beyond the instrument. And I found out at the same time, of course people are going to raise eyebrows at this, that classical musicians, although some of them have wonderful ears, by and large they are pretty much into their instrument. A clarinet player hears the world in relation to the clarinet. And this is a generalization but this is what I found at that time, and we are talking mid and late 50s and early 60s. The classical musicians, by and large, saw the world as revolving around their particular instrument. The jazz musicians saw a more total picture. But now again, classical musicians could tell you about Bartok and Beethoven and the jazz musicians in those days couldn't. So whether you wanted to hear about Beethoven and Bartok, that's another story.

MR: Is it partly because classical musicians — I don't know if I'll express this correctly — but their main role is to reproduce as closely as possible what's on the page? Does that make their vision kind of more narrow?

AR: It might. Because you're reading and interpreting the written note. And you are pleasing a conductor. And the conductor in turn of course is pleasing the people that he has to please. But you are relegated to the written note. There's no latitude. There's no emotional freedom in that sense, as there is in jazz. So that, yes, I would say that's a good factor.

MR: It's curious, I was talking to my daughter this weekend, she had done an area all-state type thing and was complaining about certain people who were sitting next to her because she was first chair, and there was some sniping.

AR: What does she play?

MR: She is a French hornist. And there was some, you know, what did you get on your NYSSMA, that kind of thing. And I said, "You know, that kind of thing probably goes all the way up to the top." And am I right in that?

AR: In what way? I'm not sure I follow.

MR: I'm just wondering if in the classical world, or even in the jazz world, is there a certain amount of professional jealousy or kind of jockeying for position.

AR: Yeah. But that's in life. In life there is jockeying for position. Everything you do there is jockeying for position. The corporate, down to freelance, down to whatever you get into, there is always this. And unfortunately people come into New York or come into the business with the idea that their instrument and their ability and their talent is going to carry them and that should make them a star. And they get very, very perturbed when they find out that the business suddenly looms its ugly face and they have to cope with the business. They have to cope with, as they say on your report card in public schools, working and playing well with others. You know, they have to cope with this. And a lot of them are really, and this is jazz and symphonic and whatever, commercial musicians, a

lot of them are really not aware of being a person as well as being a musician. And those that learn do better than those that don't learn. Many people come into town with a — we'll call it an attitude. And they go out of town with the same attitude. But they go out of town.

MR: Yeah. So a contractor, if he's looking at his list of people to call, he will also be considering their personalities.

AR: Oh, you better believe it. Absolutely. You can get, given the bass trombone, you can get five guys to play the bass trombone part. And two of them will argue with you. So they're not going to get called. The third guy might not show up on time. So he's not going to get called. Leaving two. And out of the two, well so-and-so is a nicer guy than so-and-so. You know? All playing being equal. All five of them can play the same let's say. But you're going to go with somebody that just kind of rubs you the right way. Absolutely.

MR: I guess Milt Hinton was the classic example of—

AR: Milt was, oh, Mr. Perfect.

MR: Yeah, right.

AR: Milt was absolutely wonderful. There's nobody that doesn't love Milt Hinton. Just like Joe Wilder. There's nobody that doesn't love Joe. There are certain people that are around here that are just absolutely brilliant musicians and the nicest people in the world.

MR: Right. They make you feel good to be with them.

AR: Oh Milt was a sweetheart. Clark Terry is another. There are so many.

MR: Right. When you think back early in your career, was there certain milestones that you reflect on now that were important, as like Gerry Mulligan or—

AR: Very much so. I came into the business with the ability to play the trombone. I played a Broadway show, I did the music hall, I did the operas and the classical music. I did do Larry Elgart, on bass trombone by the way so I was playing first trombone on the classical end of it and I was playing bass trombone on the jazz end let's say, not really jazz at that point but on the dance band end of it. When — a tremendous milestone was Gerry Mulligan. I remember walking, I was at the union and Dick Hickson, who is a bass trombone player, a very busy one in those days, happened to be on the same path as me. And we said hello and he looked and he said, "Oh yeah, you play bass trombone too, don't you?" He said, "You know Gerry Mulligan is putting a band together" you know so I said, "well do you happen to have his number?" He says, "Yeah as a matter of fact I do." So he gave me his number and I said, "Would you mind very much if I used your name as a reference?" "Yeah you can use my name." So I called up Gerry that night, from Staten Island where I was living. And I told him who I was. He said, "Well where have you played?" I said, "Oh well, I played with Larry Elgart." He says, "Well this is a

jazz band." I said, "Well I'm quick." He says, "Come on down." That was it. That was the end of the conversation. I went down to the rehearsal. I sat next to Brookmeyer. Now Gerry, letting me into his band was a big moment for me. Because I stayed with the band for three years, I re-joined the band eighteen years later and stayed for another year or so, and musically it was a wonderful experience. Brookmeyer was the person in my life that I learned the most from. Sitting next to Bob. I always prided myself on my reading ability. I was a good reader. I could read music, and at sight, and balance and blend and listen beyond the horn and all of that. And I sat down next to Brookmeyer and it was like I couldn't read at all. He would not only read a new arrangement, let's say a George Russell complex arrangement, but he would read it the first time down in the style that the band was going to play after they played it twenty-five times or so. But Bob would do it right at the opening. He would do the right inflections with the right style, with the right nuances. And I can't say I never heard him make a mistake, but I can't recall him making a mistake. And sitting next to him from the first rehearsal on I had the ability to play outside of my instrument. So I was playing his instrument. Whatever he did I phrased the same way. And he was playing first trombone. It was interesting because it was valve trombone on first, slide trombone on second, and bass trombone on third. Wayne Andre was the slide trombone. Whatever Brookmeyer did I would do it as quick as I could so that it would almost seem I were doing it too. I would just listen intently. I was playing through his horn. And I learned a lot.

MR: Sorry to interrupt, is that what you mean by playing outside your instrument?

AR: Yeah. Playing your instrument means you're involved with the instrument, the intonation, trying to fit in, trying to get the right sound and loud and soft and fast and slow and all of that. Playing outside of your instrument means almost like looking at yourself from beyond yourself and seeing how you fit in, realizing when you have the melody, when you don't have the melody, when you have a leading line, when you should not be heard, and when it's completely unimportant whether you play or not. I always choose not to play in those cases. But there are many, many times where it just doesn't matter. You hear yourself being doubled over here and over there — I'm not talking about Mulligan's band now, I'm just talking about average commercial. And there are many times that if you drop a note or two it absolutely doesn't matter a bit. Nobody's going to even care much less say anything. So you are hearing beyond what you're doing. There are people though that live, eat and breathe the trombone. And everything they do is through the trombone. And there are some good musicians that do it that way too. Brookmeyer goes beyond that. He's a superb player and what was interesting, what I learned, one of the things I learned from him in jazz playing you never knew where he was going to come in from. You would hear other players, and even Gerry, you'd have an idea of what he's

going to do in a certain tune at a certain tempo. Brookmeyer, you had an idea of the overall, but you never knew how he was going to attack it, and he always surprised you. He always surprised you. And it was a pleasant surprise. I remember listening to "Body and Soul" night after night after night and I would try and outguess him and I never did, not even once. And Wayne and I would look at each other like oh my God, isn't this wonderful.

MR: Yeah. Boy. Wish you could grab a little of that kind of creativity. That was what years?

AR: That was '61, '62.

MR: What was the work scene like for that band and that style of music. Those were tough years weren't they?

AR: How much did the band work. The band probably didn't work as much as the bands during the 40s worked. They were out — Benny Goodman's band, and some of the earlier bands were working a lot. Mulligan would do weekends at a club in Jersey perhaps, or he'd do something in Upstate New York, he'd do some run outs from New York. We did a couple of tours. We toured this country and it was mainly one-nighters. We went to Europe. We were busy in Europe. But sporadic would have to be the word. Because there were times when the band didn't work very much. We would do Newport and we'd do a couple of the festivals and then lay off for the rest of the summer.

MR: What kind of money were you making with that group?

AR: I asked for a little more money and he paid it, and then he resented it. So we had a little tete-a-tete. At one point I was playing with Mulligan for I guess a year and he was going to go to Europe. So Nick Travis was calling the guys. He was acting as personnel manager. Nick was first trumpet player with the band. And I was offered a Broadway show, I was offered "Music Man." It was running already but the first trombone player was leaving and the conductor wanted me to come in and play. So I had that as a springboard. That would have given me $350 a week. So I felt that instead of asking for $250, which I knew everybody more or less was getting on Gerry's band, I asked for $300. And I got it. I wasn't the highest paid guy by any means, but I was making a little more than two or three of the other guys in the band. So $300. I went to Europe for $300 a week, which was decent in those days.

MR: Yeah. Did you have to pay your own way, I mean like your own meals and all that kind of stuff?

AR: Meals yes. And oh my — I don't remember if we paid the rooms or not. I don't remember. I remember signing in. But I don't remember — I have a feeling that we may have paid for the rooms, but we may have gotten an allowance. I just don't remember that.

MR: Most guys say that the audiences in Europe were different. Did you find that to be true?

AR: Now we are talking forty years ago.

MR: Yeah.

AR: Okay? I don't know how they are now. But in those days they were all — the audiences were very demonstrative and very appreciative of what you did. Very responsive. Warmer perhaps than some other audiences. But we went to Amsterdam for instance. We played there where the Concertgebouw Orchestra plays, it's a round stage. I think it's completely surrounded by audience if I remember. Well the photographers were on stage during the concert shooting flash bulbs in our eyes. And I remember Brookmeyer almost beating them away with his trombone. That was different. I hadn't seen that before. We had one very interesting experience at the Sports Palace in Berlin. This was 1961 I believe. Of course the war was over in '45. The Berlin Wall was still up. And I had a personal experience — I took the train from West Berlin to East Berlin. I got off way out in East Berlin. I wanted to make sure I was there because I couldn't tell by the map if I was passing the Brandenburg Gate or not. But I got off in East Berlin. And I had a heck of a time getting back because I didn't have any East German money. So I had to go to a store that couldn't sell me a camera because I didn't have the passport or I didn't have the right papers, and a guy from the store walked me a couple of blocks to some money changer where they changed a couple of dollars worth of west money to east money and I was able to get back. But it was scary for a minute. At the Sports Palace, which I started to say, we played a concert and I guess the concert normal length was about two hours. So we were finishing it up, we had one or two encores that we were going to play. But after we did the last number, instead of applauding, half the audience got up and left. They just left. And we couldn't understand this. We found out later that these people were from East Berlin. They had a curfew. And they already stayed past their curfew. So if they all left together they had a chance of getting back to East Berlin without facing the authorities. So they all got up en masse and left. It was the weirdest thing. We thought they enjoyed the concert and here they are running out.

MR: But they gave you a pretty high compliment by staying that late.

AR: Oh yeah, they did. They actually stayed past their curfew because they were so interested in the music.

MR: You found your way into the studio scene in New York?

AR: Yeah. I always had that in the back of my mind that I wanted to do studio work. And Mulligan, well the Elgart band was a good entree into that, and Mulligan was a very good entree into that. I started doing — through another connection I started doing a lot of the rock & roll dates. And I got fairly busy doing those things. I was doing a Broadway show and I was playing Mulligan at Birdland and I was also doing dates during the day. And I started doing some jazz dates. We did a Cy Coleman date because our bass player at the

time, Bill Takas was Cy's bass player and he contracted. So we did some Sauter-Finnegan things, we did Manny Albam, we did a number of the jazz writers. It was kind of a "get me the Mulligan band" these guys are good, let's get as many of them as we can on this date and we know we have some good guys. I was — at that point I was juggling. And juggling is the name of — that's the story of my life was juggling. Keeping Mulligan happy when I had to send a sub to the first set at Birdland every night because I was playing a Broadway show. I was doing "A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum" which let out at eleven. And Mulligan started at Birdland at nine or nine-thirty. So Benny Powell used to sub for me. And I came in and did the second and did the night. I'd finish at four o'clock and then go home and get up early and do a couple of dates and do a show and do that again. It was kind of interesting. But juggling. Keeping one contact while you make another, and then honoring the commitments. If you overbook, and you do this all the time, you book something that's right on the tail of something else and then you have the problem of trying to get out of the first thing a little bit early or come to the second thing a little bit late. And there's generally a way. I mean I only once or twice had to resort to outright subterfuge. Most of the time I could lie my way.

MR: "Oh I got stuck in traffic."

AR: I remember once breaking — my daughter at the time, my 43-year-old, had a little plastic cow and I broke its foot off and put iodine on it. In the middle of a rehearsal I reached in and said, "oh man, I just broke my tooth." I managed to get out of rehearsal. I left the trombone on the chair, just to make it look really good, and I went out, took my other trombone and went and did a brass quintet date Uptown. Every now and then I'd have to do something like that but not too often.

MR: Right.

AR: But I have told a few lies in my day.

MR: Have to be a little creative.

AR: Yeah.

MR: I didn't know Benny Powell played bass trombone.

AR: Benny studied with me. Lew Van Haney was the second trombone player with the New York Philharmonic. And Benny and two other guys from the Basie band studied with Lew. And Van Haney moved out to Indiana to take a job teaching there. And I inherited Benny Powell as a student. Benny studied with me for a couple of years. We got to be really good friends. We don't see each other a lot now, but we are good friends. We know each other and we enjoy each other. And Benny in those days was studying bass trombone with me, yes. He could play the low notes and he did all the exercises and he got himself into a good player. And I like Benny a lot.

MR: Yeah. A real gentleman.

AR: Yeah.

MR: You mentioned doing rock & roll date.

AR: Many.

MR: Did you even know the name of the bands that you were playing for sometimes?

AR: No.

MR: So you just came in, like a horn section, and they'd put the music in front of you, and you'd put the headphones on—

AR: Yeah. I had no idea.

MR: Really?

AR: I did stuff for Blood, Sweat & Tears, I did stuff for Bob Dylan. Who's the guy with the raindrops? Not Burt Bacharach, the other guy.

MR: "Raindrops Keep Falling on my Head?"

AR: Not that one the other guy.

MR: "It must be raindrops" that guy?

AR: I can't think of his name. Anyway, I'll think of his name later, after I leave here. But a lot of the various people. I did a lot of work for them. I never knew who it was going to be. And occasionally somebody would tell me you remember the date we did for so-and-so? Well they're playing it a lot. And I'd say oh did I do that? Was I on that? It just never really — I would keep an account of the jazz dates that I did, or the symphonic dates, because they to me were a little more meaningful. But some of these others, where you just sit down and play a few figures and it didn't really matter who you were playing for or what you were playing for, you just did your job and did it as well as you could.

MR: Most likely you'd get one or two passes at those things and they'd be done, right?

AR: Yeah. For the most part.

MR: Who would be sitting next to you on dates like that?

AR: Well you're going to interview Eddie Bert later on today. Eddie and I have done a lot of work together. We had a very funny situation. I remember this better than Eddie which is unusual because Eddie has got a memory like a steel trap and he's accurate. But this I remember well. We were at Stay Phillips. And we were recording Frankie Valli with the Four Seasons. Well it wasn't even Frankie Valli in those days, it was just simply The Four Seasons. And we were sitting as a band, they had an isolation booth for the singer and they had a control booth for the producer and all. And we were doing a Christmas album. And it came to the tune "O Holy Night," which starts on the third beat. So it goes [scats] "O Holy Night" and it comes in like that. Well Eddie and I were the only two trombones. We are sitting side by side looking straight into the booth, and Frankie Valli was doing a solo on this. And he could not get this. [scats] "O Holy Night" no, no, no, Frank they're telling him from the booth you know. "You have to start a little bit later."

Okay. [scats] "No Frank, you have to start earlier." And by this time he's getting into a panic. You know the eyes are starting to get wide. It must have gone on for it seemed like a long time, it was probably about ten minutes or so. And on recording time, where time is money, you know ten minutes of wasting time like that you start getting nervous. And they were getting very nervous in the booth. Eddie and I were — Eddie is very cool. He was just sort of sitting there you know and I was digging the whole thing. So finally he just wasn't getting it so the producer said, "Wait I have an idea." He sent two guys into the booth with Frankie and we did the take with them holding his mouth like this, both sides of him, and Frank was there with the eyes popping. [scats] they released his mouth, he sang the tune, we did a take. I'll never forget that. I have the record at home. I have the record at home. The record starts with [sings] "Angels from the realms of glory" oh God, you know it's that kind of a thing. Oh God, really, it's a party record. And then of course well I told the story about Frankie Valli doing "O Holy Night," you can just see it.

MR: That's really funny. That's so funny because I know what you're talking about. That song. Like even a trained musician, you have go think about this, it's tricky.

AR: Because it feels like it's on one.

MR: Right. Poor Frankie. I'm surprised that, if you guys were there, there must have been like a whole live date.

AR: It was all live. In those days the only isolation was putting the singer into a separate booth.

MR: Okay.

AR: It was all done live. Later on in the 70s and 80s then it was all overdub, nothing was live. You would go in and everything had been done already and all they wanted to do was put on brass. So it didn't matter. You put on the headphones and they'd play it to you and you'd do it. But in those days, in the 60s and in the 70s it was live.

MR: Did you ever have to deal with bad arrangers, bad copyists, those things?

AR: Constantly. You had to make them sound good. There was one expression that Charlie Calello, who was one of the successful arrangers, used to use and that was, "Make it work." I said, "Well Charlie, this is impractical." He said, "Make it work" you know. So you made it work.

MR: Yeah. You might find something different to play that's not on the paper.

AR: There were even times, and many times, when we went into a date and there might have been some sketched music but certainly not an arrangement. Or there might have been no music and they just said look we're doing this and they played a little bit of the rhythm for us, live, and we were to make up some horn fills. And I remember doing a Pepsi Cola commercial that way, where the band was a successful rock & roll band that Pepsi decided they should do the next commercial because they were hot. And these guys had

three or four solid days of studio time. I came in, my segment took about eight hours. And we just sat there making up things and discarding things, and keeping a note here and a chord there. And it was the most boring way to do it but the money was good so you didn't mind.

MR: I guess Pepsi had the money to spend at the time, right?

AR: Of course, yeah.

MR: Oh man. That's interesting.

AR: But you want to make it work. You want it to sound good. And Mel Davis, who is a wonderful trumpet player, you talk about milestones in my career, Gerry Mulligan was one, doing that band, playing with Brookmeyer was a milestone. When I started doing really good studio work and I was doing dates with Bernie Glow and Mel Davis, who were the top two trumpet players in New York City for many years, I felt well I've arrived, you know I'm doing things with these guys and I'm able to kind of hold my own with them. Mel told me something one day that spun me completely around. And I'm so happy he did. After a certain point when I realized I could play the trombone, and there was nothing out there that was going to scare me too much music-wise, I started developing an attitude of well this is all beneath me. And we were doing a date, Mel and Bernie and I were doing a thing for RCA Camden. I think it was a rip off of the Herb Alpert style. It was called "Living Brass" and it was the Herb Alpert tunes done with studio brass so that people could buy the record for two dollars instead of four dollars and they'd get the same music. In fact they'd probably hear it played better. And there was something that we were playing that was just terrible. And I remember looking at Mel saying [growls] isn't this ridiculous, look at this garbage, you know. Mel, during the break, he walks over and he puts his arm around my shoulder and he says, "Alan," he says, "we're here to sell it not to buy it." And wow did that ever change me — that changed me right there on the spot. I thought my God yes. We are here to sell it, not to buy it. Here I'm sitting there like I'm buying it. And that just turned me completely around. When you learn something you learn it immediately, like a ton of bricks. And that was a ton of bricks at that time.

MR: Wow. Very succinct he put it.

AR: Yeah.

MR: I'll have to remember that one. That's good.

AR: I've told that to many people since. But Mel laid it on me. I'm so glad he did.

MR: Were you called upon to do much improvising and soloing?

AR: Not a lot. There are two or three records that are floating around that I have a little bit of improvisation on. I did — playing with Mulligan's band at Birdland, we played opposite Dizzy Gillespie, we played opposite Art Blakey, we played opposite many very good jazz

bands. As a matter of fact it's funny, I went to school with Wayne Shorter. We both went to NYU. He was a half a year behind me. And I'm playing here with Gerry Mulligan and Wayne is playing with Art Blakey. In fact I got Wayne to write an arrangement for Mulligan's big band which he did and Gerry played, a thing called "Mama G" is one of the tunes that Gerry played with the band. But along with Wayne was Freddie Hubbard and also Curtis Fuller. And Curtis I loved. I just did an album of his called "Cabin in the Sky" right around that time when we did that particular Birdland job. And I had Brookmeyer and Willie Dennis there in the Mulligan band and Curtis walking around listening to the band. And I had the nerve to stand up and play a blues solo on one of the tunes that Gerry had, because Gerry finally — sometimes he wouldn't show up until the first couple of tunes and the band would just play something and we'd share the solos. So I would stand up occasionally and play. And I remember at one point I stood up and played this blues thing. And I thought oh my God this is horrible but I have to get through the 24 bars or whatever it is. And after it was over, after the set was over, Curtis came over and he says "hey man that was very nice." I thought oh my God. I'm in heaven. You didn't have to say that to me. So I can play but it's like you wear a sailor's hat and to your mother and father you're a sailor but to a sailor you're not a sailor. You know what I mean? I can play jazz. To a jazz player I'm not a jazz player.

MR: What was the racial scene like in the studio work? And did it change?

AR: Rock & roll was half black half white, for openers. I remember doing many dates where I might have been the only white musician and doing dates where there were a few blacks. It's hard to — there was never really a line of distinction. I think it just flowed. You went one way or the other, it didn't matter. Your friends were of all colors and it was just part of the way the world is.

MR: That's good. I'm going to play a little blindfold test with you.

AR: Oh my.

MR: But this is not the typical thing. This is a date that you're on.

AR: Okay.

MR: But I'm just curious if you'll be able to remember it. Because I know you fellas do an awful lot of things and we'll see if this rings a bell.

[audio interlude]

AR: Is that Sebesky? "Malaguena?"

MR: Okay. Very good.

AR: Yeah. That's interesting. Yeah. From his "Giant Box."

MR: Pardon?

AR: Was it from "Giant Box" or from a different album?

MR: Album was called — gosh I didn't write down the name of it.

AR: Oh it was actually Don's own band. It was Don's all-star band, Cycles I think it was. Well Okay. Jimmy Pugh and I were the two trombones and we played mostly baritone horn in that band. Don — it's an interesting story about Don — back in the 60s I used to do a lot of recording at — what's his name band — Rudy VanGelder's. And Creed Taylor used to record from there a lot. Creed had Verve Records at that time. And every now and then he'd pull some new talent — not new but unknown, relatively unknown. And he pulled in Bob James and Don Sebesky around the same time, gave them both an album, Don did "Giant Box" and Bob did a thing called "Opus 1" I believe. And Bob took off, Don didn't. At least the way I saw it. And this is a worm's eye view because I'm not seeing it from on top I'm just seeing it from how it happened to hit me. Bob became an international star. And Don was well known, did wonderful arrangements, was busy, but he wasn't an international star. Now, years down the road he started this band, and this started in the 80s, around '85. And the first band, which I think this record is, had Faddis and Soloff playing trumpets and Jimmy and I were playing trombone, Eddie Daniels was in the band, Alex Foster, Jimmy Madison played drums and Jay Leonhart played bass. It was a really good band that he called the New York All-Star Band. And it made a little bit of noise. We played some of the clubs and it kind of established Don now as a bandleader of some repute. Prior to that he was an arranger. Now he is a band leader. And he wore it well, he still does. We've done a few albums since. I think I've done all of his albums with him. The most recent is the "Joyful Noise" album, which is a superb Duke Ellington — I don't know if you've heard it or not but oh God it's good. And it's one of the few albums that you are nervous for the whole date because it's hard to play. It's hard stuff to play. When you do a take and he says, "Okay that's it" you think oh thank God, you know.

MR: Isn't that curious because you've said that you had gotten to a point where not too much scared you or made you nervous.

AR: Well, I know, most of the time I was bored to death but occasionally I was scared to death you know. And it goes from one extreme to the other. There's no middle ground. Most of the time you just kind of do it. But then every now and then something comes up and you think uh oh, I'm over my head, I will not make this.

MR: Is it mostly rhythmic stuff? Or is it hard to pin it down?

AR: Rhythmic, tempo, accuracy were the considerations. Make sure that the tempo fits. Make sure that everything is gelling feel-wise, where the tempo comes into it and hitting right at the right moment. And then rhythms because a whole big thing because you don't have a lot of time to learn the arrangement. If you're playing with a band that plays it every night, after a week or so you know it. But having it on a recording, seeing it for the first time, the second and third time you're really intent on making sure that you're reading

exactly what's written. Because it's easy to confuse a figure with something else. It's easy to poke in a note. And those are some of the considerations. Technically — there were some technical things too.

MR: How about classical experiences? Are there any particular pieces — Stravinsky or anything like that — you've ever had really challenging work in the symphonic world?

AR: Yeah. I recorded "Forest of the Amazon" with Villa Lobos and that had some moments. And there are a number of symphonic things. Yeah. There were moments, a lot of moments.

MR: I got to watch the Nashville Symphony rehearse "The Rite of Spring" once, and I was watching the score and I just couldn't understand how can you play this?

AR: You know, I did it last year with a local symphony, the Ridgefield Symphony. I played bass trumpet. And it was the first time I ever played bass trumpet on "The Rite of Spring." And the bass trumpet does not play much, but when it plays it's out there, you hear it. And it took some counting and it took a little bit of paying attention. And it came off but I didn't just toss it off as well here's something else to do. I was on the edge of my chair more than the back of the chair.

MR: I wanted to mention a couple of people here that you've worked with. Quincy Jones?

AR: I love Quincy. I love Quincy. He kissed me. Did I tell you that?

MR: Really?

AR: Yeah.

MR: Never wash that cheek again.

AR: Yeah, right. We did, he did "The Wiz," the movie "The Wiz," which was huge sessions of many, many musicians. In fact on one session I played tuba along with Dave Bargeron, Don Butterfield and Tony Price. There were four tubas on this one particular session. And on another session I played bass trombone, and there were about six or eight trombones on the thing. And after the sessions were over I got a call from the contractor, could I come down to A&R and overdub something. So I came down. Tony Price was there. I came down on bass trombone. Tony was playing tuba. Both of us had to reinforce a bass line of one of the arrangements. It was about a three page, three trombone page arrangement. Sort of an uptempo and fairly busy. And we sat down and we played it and they took a balance and they recorded it. We played it twice. The second time was the take, and that was it. So we walked in to listen to it and Quincy's listening to it, and he gets up and kisses me on the cheek, which meant see you later.

MR: Good work.

AR: Yeah. I love Quincy. He deserves more than the success he's got. I mean he's the most successful person in the world and he deserves that plus.

MR: Great. How about Aaron Copland.

AR: I worked with Aaron not much, with a little orchestra society. Bob Megel was playing first trumpet, I was playing first trombone. Aaron came into conduct his theater music and I think that's the only time I ever worked for him, or with him. He conducted the concert, which means that we did two or three rehearsals and maybe one or two concerts. So I can't really put a handle on it.

MR: When you do a symphonic concert, do you get the music beforehand?

AR: No.

MR: So it's not that much different.

AR: Well these days there's more of a tendency for the orchestra, for the orchestral musicians to get the music beforehand. The Ridgefield Symphony sends out music. Other symphonies do, other bigger symphonies, and more better symphonies do the same. If it's a matter of repertoire you've probably played or you probably know the excerpts. If it's new stuff guys do ask for their parts but I never did and to my knowledge it wasn't done a lot in the 50s and 60s. You just came in and played it, you came in and read it. I saw some astounding reading from classical musicians, really wonderful reading. I don't know. Maybe the string players all had their part, I don't know, but it was never apparent to me that they did. I was always under the impression that we were all in the same boat. It might have been naïve on my part.

MR: Right. But I guess that's part of the gig is to know the basic repertoire.

AR: Know the repertoire, know how to play, know how to read, know how to divide notes and all of that, and how to balance and blend at the first reading. I never did. I never got music in advance. Well once or twice I did. On J.J.'s last album, on the brass orchestra, Slide Hampton called me up. I was playing baritone horn. Bruce Bonvusato and myself played baritones and they had trombones and horns and all the rest. But Slide called and he said, "Would you mind coming up to the apartment, I'd like to show you these parts." So he showed me and I looked at it and there were a lot of finger things, I thought I think I better take this one home. And I did. And I'm glad I did because came the date I had already gotten a little bit of fingers together and I was able to get through the date. Otherwise it would have been a struggle. So that's one of the few times that I actually did take music home.

MR: Yeah, he writes some challenging music.

AR: Slide is, oh he's a marvelous, marvelous writer. I just heard him recently in Danbury with Faddis and with a wonderful piano player named Cyrus Chestnut. And Slide sounded marvelous. During the intermission he was apologizing about how rotten he sounded but that's Slide. He doesn't know how good he sounds. He sounded just wonderful. Playing a big horn.

MR: I see you've worked on "Sesame Street?"

AR: Yeah. I never did it as a steady job but they have a character there called Telly monster. And he plays — they call it a tuba, it turns out to be like an E flat alto horn that's all smashed up and he kind of holds it while a tuba player plays the tuba. And I was the tuba player on many occasions. So a lot of the episodes where Telly monster has some sort of carryings on about playing tuba or dropping it or losing it or whatever, the tuba that you hear is me. Joe Raposo and I were friends for years. We both studied with Nadia Boulanger back in 1956. That's where I met Joe. In fact at that time we would take our private lesson with her, we would take a class lesson with her, we'd sit in the studio and play, and then at night there was a French and an English Army base, two different bases, in Fountainbleu, France. And I put together a little combo. And we used to go play these places. We'd make like six dollars a night or so. But it was something to do at night. Joe was the piano player.

MR: Oh Joe Raposo was.

AR: Joe Raposo, yeah.

MR: Neat. I think Quincy took from her also.

AR: I think he might have, yeah. He was with Dizzy Gillespie's World Statesmen Band, and they went down to South America and the first place he went was over to Villa Lobos and he hung out with him. Quincy was always searching, always looking. Yeah, there ain't much wrong with Quincy.

MR: You decided to get another degree.

AR: I decided to get the master's, after getting the bachelor's, just simply because I was doing shows at that time and I had the time. I think I was doing a Broadway show that looked like it was going to last for a while, I forget which one it was, but it was on the books for about a year or so, so I went to Teacher's College and horse traded my way into a degree.

MR: And has it paid off?

AR: It's paid off insofar as it gives me a little credibility as far as knowing what I talk about educationally and instrument wise and all of that. I have a number of publications on the market, mostly through Carl Fisher, and in writing my bio in the books I'm able to naturally state that I have this degree and that degree, which means a lot with a lot of teachers. I also developed the vocabulary in taking education degrees to reach students a little bit better than I might have otherwise. It was just — that was the field that I thought I should get a little extended education in. I started for a doctorate and at that point I looked in the mirror and I thought come on, a doctorate, yeah, right, no I'm not going to do that. So I took two courses and that was it. But that's how I met Mary Ann and we started going out together and ultimately got married. I met her at Teacher's College. I was teaching there actually. I had a class where I had to teach all the instruments. And

she was the only student. They let her take the class. So naturally one thing led to another and we've been married now 23 years.

MR: Cool. My goodness. Wynton Marsalis you've played behind?

AR: Yes. Once. Yeah it was wonderful. I was so nervous. I got a call from Art Baron that he recommended me for a Wynton Marsalis Lincoln Center concert because they were doing the music of Gerry Mulligan. And I was to play tuba and bass trombone. So I went and I went into Carroll Studios with the tuba and the bass bone and I just sat there very quietly and Wynton came in and there was sort of a lull so I went up to him and I said, "Excuse me" I said "my name is Alan Raph," and the next thing I know he's hugging me. It was the warmest thing. I thought oh my God. So immediately I fell in love with Wynton. Then I saw the way he rehearsed the band and the way he worked and it was on the money. It was just so good. I enjoyed a lot working with him, and I enjoyed almost as much, in a different way, meeting Wycliffe Gordon. Wycliffe — you look at him and you just don't think he's going to get that trombone in his face fast enough to play, because he doesn't set, he picks up the horn and he's playing like this. And then he's off in space somewhere and the next thing you know he's playing again. You don't see this kind of setting up guys do. And he plays astoundingly well. And he's incredibly good. So I listened to that, I listened to him play the sousaphone and we got talking a little bit and at one point I brought in that book that I gave you, "Le Trombone" it's kind of a funny book that I did that's out on the market. I gave him a copy of that. He brought me a CD that he did with somebody else. And we got talking. He said to me, he says, "Hey I've got to take a couple a tuba lessons with you." I says, "Yeah, I'll teach you everything I know in five minutes." He is a wonderful tuba player and just an outstanding trombone player. I enjoyed it. It was a nice week. It was just a week.

MR: Do you make an effort to get copies of the recordings you play on?

AR: Yeah. The ones that are good, I have them all. I also have all the programs of every concert that I've ever played from the 50s.

MR: Wow. That's great, you know. Most guys don't think to do that.

AR: No I did. I made a point out of that. There are some records that I played on that I probably don't have but most of them I do have. The ones that were meaningful. I mean a lot of the schlock things I don't even bother with. But these days, now I'm not going into the City on a regular basis, but what I do do still, at this point, and right now this is now November 2001, I still do pretty much all of Don Sebesky's stuff. I do John Pizzarelli when he uses a big band, we have a couple of things coming up next month, and I do all of Phillip Glass's work. And I've been doing Phillip Glass for a lot of years as I have for Sebesky. And Pizzarelli of course is a little more recent. But I have those three that I hang on to. I don't go into town, I don't sub shows, I should say I don't go into town on a

regular basis. And on a regular basis means you do a Broadway show or you sub a Broadway show. I don't do that anymore. But I do go in for dates and things.

MR: Can you, on that limited basis, can you tell how has the scene changed in the last ten years, or has it? You know this is not really new, but electronics replacing—

AR: Oh okay. Well we all went through that. I never considered myself a barometer of the business, even at my busiest. There were always guys that were busier and that knew more than I did about the business, and especially now I'm certainly nowhere near being able to put an accurate handle on it. But the way it seems to me is guys are working a little bit harder and they're going out of town a little bit more — the good guys — they're really traveling a bit more, they're doing a little more road work than, at one point, than I used to. Because I could maintain — I had a studio in town on 50th Street and 7th Avenue. I had that studio for 25 years. I kept all my instruments there. I never once brought an instrument home, because I had instruments home and I had instruments there, and I just used what's there. Warm-up in the morning, go out, work during the day and do what I had to. I've always done clinics and solos for King instruments, which is now United Musical Instruments. So I'm playing a King, a Benge and also a Conn on occasion. I'm doing things for them still. Last year we went to Ireland and we had the first ever trombone day in Bantry, Ireland, which I set up. The year before we went to Australia and I did a couple of clinics in Western Australia. I'm bringing my brass band to Australia this coming summer, 2002, and I'm going trombone day number two in Bantry in three months, in February. All of this, you know, is sort of a reflection on my doing clinics and solos. It's that particular hat that I'm wearing. And United Musical Instruments has been sponsoring a little bit of that. They've been helpful. I dropped the ball there somewhere with the conversation.

MR: Oh, we were just talking about the state of the business I guess.

AR: I've always gone my own way. I've always done what I thought would be helpful to me. I've tried to get as much experience as I could in all types of music and then hopefully cash in on that experience. I've done that. Whereas most of the guys in a particular band would be of a particular type of musician doing certain types of work, I always found that I was doing other stuff, which is one of the reasons that I probably don't talk too much to A about B or left hand about what the right hand is doing. I just kind of keep everything in its own place. I wear a lot of hats. I play church organ these days. I'm playing at a Maronite church in Danbury, I'm president of the musician's union, the local A F of M local 87 in Danbury, and I have the brass band as I mentioned. But I wear a lot of different hats. I do the trombone and the tuba and keyboard and teaching and writing. I have something — I have about eight or nine things out with Carl Fisher and there's

something in the works right now and there's another thing that we're talking about so I've been doing a bit of writing for them.

MR: You said you're still a morning person, even though you're a musician.

AR: Oh yeah. I've always been a morning person.

MR: When you write are you a sit at the piano and write person?

AR: Sometimes. It depends. If I'm composing I'm writing something truly original, very often I'll sit at the piano. But if I'm arranging something it doesn't really matter. I've gotten into Finale, using the computer and Finale and all of that and I'm just getting over the hurdle of being restricted, actually restricted by Finale, because things are so easy that you end up doubling things that you might not have doubled. You end up using sections of things that you might not have used if you were writing pen and ink. Finale is easy to take a whole section and stick it in later on, or to transpose something or to have something for one French horn and decide to stop it down for the second and third French horn also. It's just so easy to do that sometimes, I think, I'm getting over the cluttering aspects of that.

MR: Yeah, that's interesting that you say that, how technology —

AR: My writing prior to Finale was a little more transparent and it's starting to get transparent again, which I kind of like.

MR: Okay. Yeah. Let the machine do a little bit of the work for you.

AR: Yeah. But I love it. I mean oh, not having to copy parts. That's the whole ball game.

MR: Who are your three favorite trombone players?

AR: Buddy Morrow—

MR: Buddy Morrow.

AR: Who I love. Buddy is 82 years old, he's still out with the Tommy Dorsey band. And I like Buddy a lot. Urbie Green. And Brookmeyer.

MR: Yeah.

AR: And running very close to them are quite a few other guys. But those three I suppose I would have to say would be my three favorite.

MR: Here's a question you probably won't be able to think of but I'll try it anyway. Can you remember one of the worst or most ridiculous recording dates that you've ever done?

AR: Yeah. Well ridiculous, not worst.

MR: Well okay. Ridiculous is good.

AR: I was with Warren Covington on a schlock rock & roll date at a horrible studio back in the 60s. And there was a black singer, a lady, and the studio was kind of dirty, funky is a better word, dirty. And she was singing a song called "The Ghoul in School" which went "I was lying in my bed/in my school out of town/when all of a sudden/I heard a horrible sound." And then you have [scats/sings] "it was the ghoul, in school." As bad as it can

get. It was just rotten, absolutely rotten, retched. Now she sang this. We played it. Now it's break time. You have to know Warren Covington. Warren Covington was a wonderful trombone player, had his own band and he was like Mr. Indiana, with the sweater, always looked nice, always had his face washed and hands and nails manicured and the whole thing, he was just as collegiate as he could be you know. And about twelve years older than me I guess. We were the only two trombones. We're sitting there. And now the singer comes off, and we actually did it with her on a little stage up front so it was a completely live date. She comes off during the break and walks past Warren, and Warren is spraying his slide. And she walks past Warren and she stops, she says, "Don't you spit at me mother." Well Warren got so embarrassed. I mean he was dumbfounded, I was dumbfounded. And she stood there. She's like, "You've got no right to spit at me." And we are looking like my God, you know. So Warren immediately starts going into his school teacher routine. "Oh no, please, I would never, you see we trombone players" and he starts going with this whole thing — we trombone players — use the slide you know. Well he looks to me for help. And I couldn't talk I was on the floor. I couldn't breathe I was laughing so hard. It was just like, you got it. Oh God that was funny. It was just hilarious. Well she wouldn't let up. She gave him about five minutes of what a rotten person he was and how dare he do this and — she was sort of like ghettoish anyhow. So she's not using the king's English, she's like really lacing into him from Funksville you know. And Warren was beside himself. He just, he didn't know how to stop it. As it went on it just got funnier and funnier. I mean I had trouble breathing. Anyhow, that's, talk about ridiculous, that was one of the ridiculous ones.

MR: That's great. You actually got paid to laugh that hard. Well did you get paid, I don't know.

AR: Jimmy Cleveland and I were on a rock & roll date where we could hardly play, we were breaking each other up with comments about the music and everything. And we finally got to the point where it was really a struggle to just play. I don't think we worked for that guy again.

MR: Yeah. What was it — you're not buying it you're selling it. A little hard to remember that in those situations.

AR: This was beyond sell.

MR: Yeah, right. Good story. Glad I asked. In the future, you're writing more stuff, you're selective about your dates?

AR: Writing a lot. Actually a large part of my life right now is my ten-year-old. I want to stay around long enough to give her a good shot at life. So the more years I can keep going and staying active in all of that, the better chance she has of relating and learning some

things that might be a little bit more difficult to learn otherwise. So that's a big part of my life right now. I spend a lot of time with her, and we have a good relationship.

MR: Excellent.

AR: And what the future — it's a funny thing to say the future, because I'm doing a lot of writing, and these trombone days that I have and the clinics and the Australian trip and all of that, these are in the future. I've always been a person looking in the future. I don't look back. And I really have trouble — you know you're asking me certain things that have happened, and I can remember them, but I don't dwell on the past. I don't think about well gee things used to be and wouldn't it be nice if they still were and all of that. That's absolutely ridiculous. So I'm always looking to the future. What am I going to have for lunch today. You know? What's going to go on tomorrow, how's next week's particular thing going to go down.

MR: That's a positive attitude.

AR: Yeah.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking with you.

AR: It's been fascinating being here. Thanks, Monk.

MR: Great. Appreciate it.